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**FEDERAL UNIVERSITY OF PETROLEUM RESOURCES,
EFFURUN**

PROJECT WORK BY PETROLEUM ENGINEERING DEPARTMENT

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COURSE: COMMUNICATION SKILLS IN ENGLISH

COURSE CODE: GSE 122

TOPIC:

DIRECT AND INDIRECT SPEECH

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DIRECT AND INDIRECT SPEECH

In English Grammar, the term *speech* refers to the processes of communication and expressing one's thoughts through conversations or expositions. Now, the words we say can either be reported directly or indirectly. This then leads us to the two ways a speech may be reported. Which are:

1. Direct speech
2. Indirect speech

When we speak, we are either communicating directly using our own words, ideas, expressions, or viewpoints, or we are quoting someone else's words, ideas, expressions, or viewpoints. This method of speaking without altering the original words of the speaker is referred to as direct speech.

The direct speech is used to report or rather rephrase the words spoken by the speaker or writer, in their original form. The words spoken by the speaker or writer are enclosed within inverted commas or quotation marks. Direct speech is the way to represent the words spoken by the speaker or writer verbatim.

Examples:

Mr. Esemefafe said, "I am your lecturer for this course."

The student said, "The examination is getting closer by the minute."

John said "I am not hungry."

"I have been to the Hollywood hills," he told me.

The coach said, "Hurrah! we won the match!"

In the case of indirect speech, it is used to report the words spoken by someone in a paraphrased manner. It can also be called *reported speech*. Indirect speech focuses more on the context of what someone has said rather than on their exact words.

Examples:

Mr. Esemefafe said that he was the lecturer for that course.

The student said that the examination was getting closer by the minute.

John said that he was not hungry.

He told me that he had been to the Hollywood hills.

The coach exclaimed with joy that they had won the match.

Florian Coulmas reported in 1986 that while direct speech appears to provide a verbatim interpretation of words that were spoken, indirect speech is more variable in its claim to

represent a faithful report of the content and form of words that were spoken. It is important to note, however, that the question of whether and how faithful a given speech report actually is, falls into a quite different category. Both direct and indirect speech are stylistic devices for conveying messages. Direct speech is used as if the words being used were those of another, which are therefore pivoted towards a deixis centre different from the speech situation of the report. In contrast, indirect speech has its deixis centre in the reporting situation and is variable with respect to the extent to which faithfulness to the linguistic form of what was said is being claimed.

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN DIRECT AND INDIRECT SPEECH

Highlighted below are some differences between direct speech and indirect speech:

USE OF QUOTATION MARKS

Direct speech involves quoting the exact words uttered by the person, within inverted commas or quotation marks.

For example:

She said, "I won't be coming home tonight." Note that in this type of speech, a comma is most often used before starting the exact quote within the inverted commas.

On the other hand, indirect speech does not have to be within quotes or reported word-for-word. In fact, unless one is relaying the exact words spoken, one should never use quotation marks.

For example:

She told us that she wouldn't be coming home that night.

CHANGE IN VERB TENSE

Verb tense necessarily changes in reported speech but does not change in direct or quoted speech. This is because when we report speech, we are talking about something that was said in the past. Hence, it becomes necessary to use the past tense of the verb.

For example:

Direct speech: He said, "I'm fine."

Indirect speech: He said that he was fine.

Direct speech: He said, "I've been married for three years."

Indirect speech: He said that he had been married for three years.

Direct speech: He said, "I went to the theatre yesterday."

Indirect speech: He said that he had gone to the theatre the day before.

Direct speech: He said, "The show was already underway when the chief guest arrived."

Indirect speech: He said that the show was already underway when the chief guest arrived. (no change in tense)

Another thing to note is that modal verbs will, can, must, shall, may also change, taking their past tense forms would, could, had to, should, might respectively. This also means that would, could, should, might and ought to, do not change forms when reported.

A direct speech does not use the conjunction 'that,' but an indirect speech uses the conjunction 'that,' as can be seen clearly from the examples given above.

Question marks are used in direct speech, unlike in indirect speech, in which question marks are not necessary and verbs like asked, inquired, etc., are used.

Examples:

Direct speech: "What are you doing?" asked Joseph.

Indirect speech: Joseph asked (or inquired) what he was doing.

Direct speech: The woman asked me, "Where are you heading?"

Indirect speech: The woman asked where they were heading.

There are no changes in pronouns in direct speech, but changes in pronouns occur in reported speech, e.g., 'I' becomes 'he'.

In direct speech, there are also no changes in adverbs, but there are changes in adverbs in indirect speech, e.g., 'now' becomes 'then'.

CONVERSION OF DIRECT SPEECH TO INDIRECT SPEECH

A direct speech can be transformed into an indirect speech and vice versa using a suitable reporting verb and a linker depending on the sentence. Indirect speech is an essential tool in communication, allowing us to accurately convey what others have said while adapting the

language to fit our own context. Certainly! Let's delve deeper into the concept of indirect speech and explore more examples and explanations in daily life:

1. Changing Tenses: In indirect speech, the tense of the original sentence often changes to reflect the time of reporting.

In professional communication, this practice ensures that the reported information remains clear and accurate while accounting for the time difference between the original statement and its reporting. This aspect of tense change is crucial to maintaining the integrity of reported speech and conveying information effectively. The following conversions are common:

Present Simple → Past Simple

Present Continuous → Past Continuous

Present Perfect → Past Perfect

Past Simple → Past Perfect

Will → Would

Can → Could

For example:

Direct Speech: "I am reading a book."

Indirect Speech: She said she was reading a book.

Direct Speech: "I will meet you tomorrow."

Indirect Speech: He said he would meet me the next day.

2. Changing Pronouns: Pronouns also shift in indirect speech to match the perspective of the reporting speaker. This is particularly true for first and second person pronouns.

- The first person of reported speech changes based on the subject of the reporting verb.

For example:

Direct speech: She said, "I watched a movie".

Indirect speech: She said that she had watched a movie.

Hence, the first person in the direct speech "I" has become "she" based on the subject.

Had there been "he" instead of "she", the first person in reported speech changes accordingly into "he".

- The second person in reported speech changes based on the object of the reporting verb.

For example:

Direct speech: She said to me, "You watched a movie".

Indirect speech: She told me that I had watched a movie.

3. Changing Adverbs of Time and Place: Adverbs of time and place also undergo changes to align with the reporting context.

Today → That day
Now → Then
Here → There
This → That
These → Those
Here → There
Now → Then
Tonight → That night
Tomorrow → The next day
The day after tomorrow → In two days
Last → Previous
Hence → Thence

For example:

Direct Speech: "I will call you later today."

Indirect Speech: She said she would call me later that day.

Direct Speech: "I am busy now."

Indirect Speech: He mentioned he was busy then.

4. Changing Modal Verbs: Modal verbs like can, could, may, might, shall, should, will, would, must, etc., are also modified in indirect speech. Certainly, when dealing with indirect speech, the adjustment of modal verbs is a crucial aspect that contributes to maintaining accuracy and coherence in the reported statement. Modal verbs such as "can," "could," "may," "might," "shall," "should," "will," "would," and "must" undergo changes to reflect the nuances of reported speech.

In the process of reporting someone else's words, modal verbs often shift to reflect the reporting speaker's interpretation of the original statement. For instance, "can" might change to "could," "may" could change to "might," and "shall" could change to "should." These alterations accommodate the reporting speaker's perspective and convey the intended meaning of the original statement accurately within the context of reporting.

Can → Could
May → Might
Shall → Should
Will → Would
Must → Had to

For example:

Direct Speech: "I can help you with that."

Indirect Speech: She said she could help me with that.

Direct Speech: "You must finish the assignment."

Indirect Speech: He insisted that I had to finish the assignment.

5. Reporting Verbs: The choice of reporting verb can convey the attitude or mood of the reporting speaker toward the original speaker's words. Absolutely, the selection of a reporting verb holds significant influence over the portrayal of the reporting speaker's attitude or mood towards the original speaker's words in indirect speech. Reporting verbs serve as a conduit for conveying not only the content of the reported statement but also the reporting speaker's perspective on it.

For instance, a reporting verb like "asserted" or "stated" portrays a neutral or factual tone, merely presenting the information without added interpretation. On the other hand, verbs like "claimed," "argued," or "suggested" imply a level of skepticism or uncertainty regarding the accuracy of the original statement.

For example:

She admitted that she had made a mistake.

He denied stealing the cookies.

6. Punctuation and Quotation Marks: In indirect speech, quotation marks are not used, and the reported speech is often introduced by verbs like said, told, asked, mentioned, etc. The reported speech is typically separated from the introductory verb by a conjunction like "that."

For example:

Direct Speech: "I love this movie," she said.

Indirect Speech: She said that she loved that movie.

7. Exclamatory sentences and exclamations: In this rule, exclamations and exclamatory words are no longer mentioned in indirect speech. The verb is replaced by phrases like "exclaimed with joy or sorrow" or "expressed surprise," "prayed," "wished," etc.

For example:

Direct speech: They said, "What a fantastic job you have done!"

Indirect speech: They remarked with admiration that I had done a fantastic job.

8. Interrogative sentences and question mark: When converting interrogative sentences to indirect speech, the question mark (?) is not included. Verbs like "asked" and "inquired," etc., are used, and "if/whether" will replace "that."

For example

Direct speech: He said to her, "Will you marry me?"

Indirect speech: He asked her whether she would marry him.

9. Universal Truth, Habitual Actions, and Facts: Whenever the reported clause or statement of direct speech constitutes a universal truth, habitual action, or fact, there will be no change in tenses in the reported speech.

For example:

Direct speech: Mr. Bayo said, "Truth always wins."

Indirect speech: Mr. Bayo said that truth always wins.

It should also be noted that the tense in the indirect speech remains unchanged, regardless of the tense of the reporting verb (say/said).

Additional examples:

Direct speech: He said to me, "Grass is green."

Indirect speech: He told me that grass is green.

Direct speech: Our lecturer said, "The French Revolution was started in 1789."

Indirect speech: Our lecturer said that the French Revolution was started in 1789.

FREE INDIRECT SPEECH

In free indirect speech, which is commonly used in fiction, the reporting clause (or signal phrase) is omitted. Using the technique is a way to follow a character's point of view—in third-person limited omniscience—and show their thoughts intermingled with narration. It can also be seen as "the illusion by which third-person narrative comes to express...the intimate subjectivity of fictional characters."

Typically, in fiction italics show a character's exact thoughts, and quote marks show dialogue. Free indirect speech makes do without the italics and simply combines the internal thoughts of the character with the narration of the story.

Consider this example: the opening of Joyce Carol Oates' (1966) short story *Where Are You Going, Where Have You Been?* Introduces us to a young teenage girl named Connie.

"She knew she was pretty and that was everything." This sentence exhibits the use of free indirect discourse. If it were to be in the normal third-person, the sentence would read: "Connie thought she was pretty, and she believed that being pretty was the most important thing she could be."

Writers who have used this technique include James Joyce, Jane Austen, Virginia Woolf, Henry James, Zora Neale Hurston, and D.H. Lawrence.

Examples:

Direct speech: He said, "I will be there at 4PM."

Indirect speech: He said that he would be there at 4PM.

Free indirect speech: He would be there at 4PM

Direct speech: She said, "I haven't read my books since the beginning of the semester."

Indirect speech: She said that she hadn't read her books since the beginning of the semester.

Free indirect speech: She hadn't read her books since the beginning of the semester.

In conclusion, it can be observed that in free indirect speech, the narrator's voice blends with the character's thoughts or speech, providing a sense of the character's perspective while retaining the narrative voice.

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